The Lantern Keeper of Gull Point

The lighthouse at Gull Point stood on a black cliff above the sea, white as a candle, with a red band painted around its middle. Mara had lived in it all her life. She was a wiry girl of twelve with cropped copper hair, a face full of freckles, and a yellow oilskin coat that had once belonged to her mother. Every evening at dusk she climbed the one hundred and twelve iron steps to the lamp room, wiped the great glass lens with a soft cloth, and watched the sky over the water turn from gold to violet. Below her the fishing boats came home in a long line, their sails orange in the last of the sun.

Her grandfather Tobias kept the light. He was an old man with a white beard that reached the second button of his navy peacoat, and he wore brass spectacles pushed up on his forehead, where he always forgot them. His hands were brown and cracked from forty winters of salt wind.

In the kitchen at the bottom of the tower, Tobias set two bowls of fish stew on the wooden table beside the iron stove. A brass lantern hung from a hook above them, and the window behind it showed nothing but dark sea and the first stars. Mara pulled her chair close to the warmth and listened to the kettle tick. On the shelf above the stove sat the logbook, its leather cover worn soft, where every ship that had ever passed Gull Point was written in her grandfather's careful hand.

The storm came two nights later. Black clouds rolled in from the west and swallowed the moon, and rain hammered against the lighthouse until the whole tower seemed to hum. Mara woke to the sound of the shutters banging. She ran up the iron stairs in her nightdress and oilskin and found Tobias already in the lamp room, his white beard lit gold by the turning lamp, staring out at the heaving water.

Far below, between the waves, a single small light was swinging wildly. A boat. It was being driven straight toward the rocks beneath the cliff. Mara grabbed the brass signal lantern from its hook and held it up to the glass, flashing it the way her grandfather had taught her: three short, three long, three short. The little light on the water turned, slowly, away from the rocks and toward the sheltered cove.

At dawn the storm was gone. The sky over the cove was pale pink and the sea lay flat and silver, as if nothing had happened. Mara and Tobias hurried down the cliff path to the beach, where a battered rowing boat had washed up on the sand. Beside it sat a stranger wrapped in a dripping black cloak. His name, he said, was Elias. He was tall and thin, with a long dark braid and a silver ring in one ear, and he carried a leather satchel that he would not let go of, even while he shivered.

Elias stayed with them for a week while his hands healed. He mended nets on the rocks and told Mara stories about the cities across the sea, where towers were made of glass and the markets never closed. On market day they walked together into the village of Sandle, past the crooked stone houses with their blue doors, past the fish stalls and the baker with his trays of bread. Elias bought Mara a red ribbon and a paper bag of sugared almonds and would not say what was in his satchel.

On the seventh morning a thick white fog came in off the water. Mara found Elias on the cliff path above the lighthouse, standing very still, his black cloak beaded with mist. He opened the leather satchel at last. Inside was a lens, small and perfect, ground from glass so clear it seemed to hold the fog itself. It belonged to a lighthouse that had fallen into the sea, he told her, and he had been searching for a keeper worthy of it.

That night Tobias and Mara fitted the new lens into the lamp, and when they lit it the beam reached farther than it ever had, sweeping across the dark water all the way to the horizon. Elias rowed away at sunset and did not look back. Mara climbed the one hundred and twelve iron steps, wiped the glass with her soft cloth, and stood in the lamp room in her yellow oilskin under a sky full of stars, keeping the light.